GLASSHOUSE

A PM ON SONG

After telling fans to subscribe to his YouTube channel in September, Prime Minister Narendra Modi seems to have hit a purple patch creatively. In the first week of October, two garba songs penned by him were released. On October 14 came a music video titled 'Garbo', the lyrics for which the PM had apparently written a decade ago. The next day, Modi's YouTube channel released another garba video titled 'Maadi'. While 'Garbo' notched up about four million views in two days, the second video got 530,000 hits in 24 hours. The songs were released in time for the Navaratri celebrations. It'll be no surprise to hear then that Gujaratis across the world will literally be dancing to PM Modi's tune this festive season.

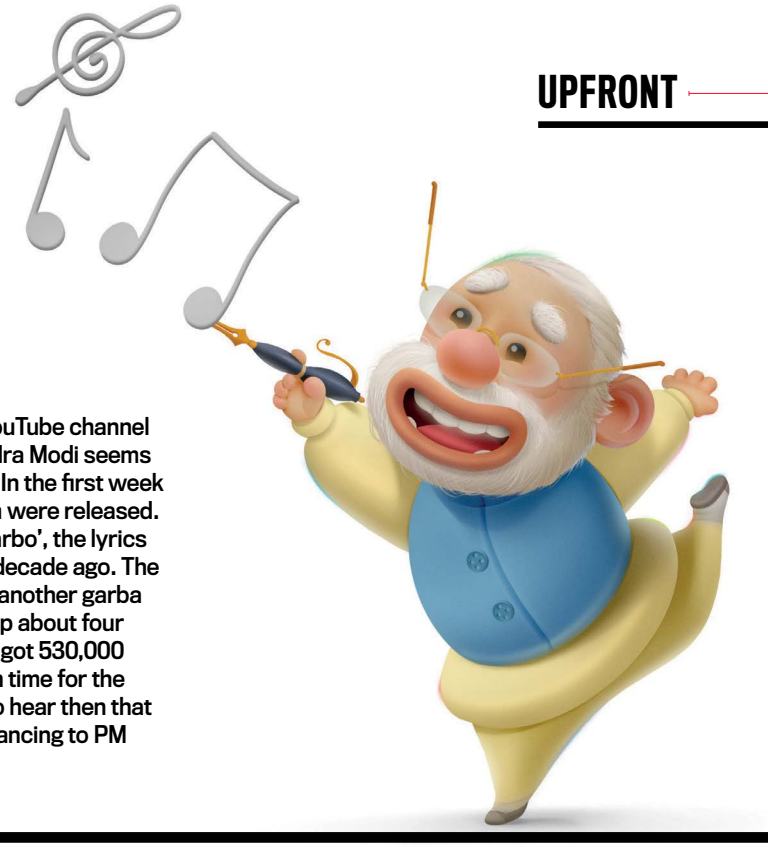


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

EPIC STRATEGY



While delivering a lecture in the national capital Delhi recently, Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) **Gen. Anil Chauhan** took his audience of top security personnel by surprise by referring to the epic Mahabharata to explain the importance of having the right strategy. Pointing to how India utilised the G20 platform to leverage its soft power, the CDS referenced how Lord Krishna shifted the balance of power to the Pandavas. The Kauravas may have preferred to have the Yadava army on their side, but it was Krishna's righteousness and sage advice that shifted the balance of power in the war, which ultimately the Pandavas won. Moral of the story: you need the right man on your side to win any war.

Taking a Toll



After almost a decade, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief **Raj Thackeray** has revived the party's agitation against toll-based projects in the state. Of course, the plan is an attempt to revive his moribund party, but sources also point to the stir leading to some 'incentives' for the middle class by the Maharashtra government in what may be a "planned move". They say if the chips fall the way Raj intends, even an electoral understanding between the MNS and the ruling Shinde-Ajit Pawar-BJP alliance cannot be ruled out.



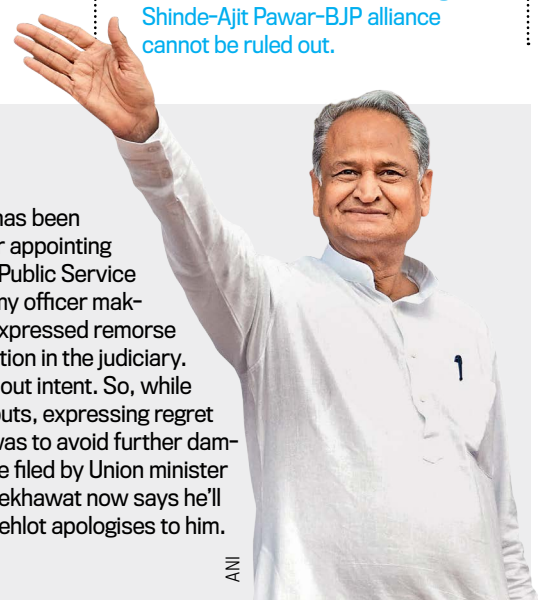
Kin vs Kin

Lok Janshakti Party (Ramvilas) chief **Chirag Paswan** recently declared that the party wants to field his mother Reena Paswan from his late father's legacy seat of Hajipur in the 2024 general election. Chirag's estranged uncle, Union minister and current Hajipur MP Pashupati Paras, who heads a rival faction of the LJP, was clearly not amused. The uncle shot back, promising to field someone from the family in Chirag's Lok Sabha seat of Jamui. Incidentally, the feuding uncle-nephew duo is part of the NDA alliance and are becoming quite the worry for the BJP.

Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Rohit Parihar, Dhaval Kulkarni, Amitabh Srivastava and Pradip R. Sagar

A SORRY PASS

Rajasthan chief minister **Ashok Gehlot** has been quite apologetic of late. He apologised for appointing Kesri Singh Rathore member of the Rajasthan Public Service Commission (RPSC) after a video of the ex-army officer making casteist comments surfaced. Gehlot also expressed remorse to the Rajasthan High Court for alleging corruption in the judiciary. But then the wily CM rarely does anything without intent. So, while Rathore's appointment was to indulge the Rajputs, expressing regret kept both sides happy. The judiciary incident was to avoid further damage after being denied relief in a contempt case filed by Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat in a Delhi court. Shekhawat now says he'll think about withdrawing the case, but only if Gehlot apologises to him.



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